

bidding for you, or you can find the property and engage the advocate to bid or negotiate the sale for you.)

Alternatively, the real estate agent who has listed the property you want to bid on can provide one of their other agents, who isn't working on the same listing, to represent you at the auction. This might not sound ideal – an agent from the same agency bidding on your behalf – but it's different to the relationship with a buyers' advocate, who is your closest confidant leading up to the sale, advising and guiding you, and who is privy to your bidding budget and full financial situation.

There is no need to tell this agent your budget, so you can keep your finances and the process private from their colleague – the listing agent, who is selling the home. During the auction, you can advise the agent, with a whisper, if you want them to raise their hand again, and by how much to increase the bid. It's a proxy move that gives you control without you having to speak up in public.

If you're too terrified to even be at the auction, let alone throw your hand up, make this known to the listing agent well in advance so legal steps can be taken to facilitate this; your proxy's signature on the contract, inked after the weekend auction, will be superseded on Monday morning by your signature, Benson says. 'An auctioneer can also sign the contract of sale in your absence,' he advises.

Adhere to your financial limit

This is an obvious, tired adage, but I have heard the argument so many times that you shouldn't lose a property for a \$1000 bid, and I have not seen evidence that it's wise for novices to operate that way. Each itty-bitty increment is, in isolation, a pittance, but the danger is that the slow creep will continue and you'll unwittingly exceed your budget. The advice to pay that extra \$1000 only works if the property is still inside your budget as the hammer threatens to fall, and as a first home buyer you are more likely to be at your upper limit in the auction's dying stages. This said, not bidding to your limit, through poor planning or intimidation, is just as much a mistake. Buyers' advocate Cate Bakos says that 'a bidder without a plan based on knowledge of the market and comparable sales is a bidder who could either face buyer's remorse or regret for not bidding to a more realistic level'.

Force your opponents to stretch